being recorded daily. In China, the surge was so severe that the country chose to place 26 million residents of its financial hub, Shanghai, on an indefinite lockdown. More than half of the cases there are occurring amongst the elderly and the unvaccinated.

On April 9, United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres drew attention to the frequency of Covid peaks in Europe and Asia, largely blamed on a relaxation of Covid-appropriate behaviour, unvaccinated populations and sub-variants of the current dominant variant, Omicron. In Britain, for example, 57 per cent of cases are due to the BA.2 sub-variant of the original Omicron variant BA.1, which began to spread rapidly as soon as the country began to abandon Covid restrictions from the end of January. The XE variant is made up of genetic material from both BA.1 and BA.2. So far, no death has been recorded from XE.

After months of being manacled by Covid protocols, India, too, is seeing the impact of a certain laxity—masks are no longer mandatory in Telangana and Delhi, and states such as Maharashtra, West Bengal have reduced Covid restrictions in public places. Delhi, Haryana and Gujarat showed a significant increase in new infections over the last week. Delhi recorded 943 fresh Covid cases, a 26 per cent increase from the previous week, while Haryana witnessed a nearly 50 per cent rise with 514 new infections. And, with physical classes starting in schools, there have been spurts of Covid cases amongst students in NCR areas of Noida and Greater Noida in recent days, spreading concern. Hospitalisations, however, remain reassuringly low, with the capital having only 0.48 per cent of its beds occupied as on April 11.

However, with the new XE variant of Omicron beginning to pick up pace globally, Union health secretary Rajesh Bhushan has written to Delhi, Maharashtra, Kerala, Mizoram and Haryana to warn them of cases creeping up as Covid protocols are ignored.

XE is already suspected to be in India, with two potential cases reported—one in Gujarat and the other in Maharashtra. Both patients reported mild symptoms. However, INSACOG, the pan-India consortium of 38 labs tasked with monitoring of variants, is still validating the sequences to confirm the presence of XE. "The Omicron variant is giving rise to new variations, and we are taking steps to monitor and manage infections," says National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation (NTAGI) chief N.K. Arora.

Variant XF and the current Variant XE, which has mutations from BA.1 (the original Omicron variant) and BA.2 (its more infectious sub-strain). XE has three mutations that aren't present in all BA.1 or BA.2 strains, according to the UK Health Security Agency (UKHSA), which makes it 10 per cent more transmissible than BA.2. However, the WHO's April 5 report indicates that more study is needed to confirm this figure.

The first known case of XE was detected in the UK this January 19 and has since been found in India, Thailand, Israel and Japan. There is not enough data to ascertain the severity of disease caused by XE but doctors expect it to be no worse than that by Omicron. "We haven't seen the kind of oxygen requirements of Delta in a year, but we don't know if that is due to vaccinations or a weakened virus," says Dr Aurangabadwala. Common symptoms reported with XE are similar to that of Omicron—fatigue, fever, headache, body pain, palpitations and upper



BATCH OF CONCERN Some Delhi-NCR schools have seen a rise in Covid infections

FRANCIS MASCARENHAS

WILL XE TRIGGER A WAVE?

"Sometimes an individual can get infected with two strains of different variants or two sub-strains of the same variant, and a new variant emerges with traits of both—called recombinant variants," explains Dr Rohan Aurangabadwala, a pulmonologist at the Apollo Hospital in Delhi.

According to the WHO, three hybrid or recombinant Covid strains have been identified so far—Variant XD,